Portable business evidence for AI recommendations

Joey · Black 4 · October 27 2026

Recommendations should serve the buyer. Ad spend buys visibility. Affiliate commissions reward a sale. Sponsored endorsements can sound convincing without establishing what customers generally receive. When the choice goes wrong, the consumer pays in wasted money, missed commitments and time spent fixing the problem.

A business that delivers dependable service needs a way to make that performance count in discovery. Consumers need evidence that answers their actual question: will this business deliver what matters to me?

We are asking systems of record and AI platforms to build an open standard for **portable evidence about a business that an agent can consult during discovery and selection**.

Give consumers evidence before they choose

A parent needs an order before a birthday. An affiliate list may earn a commission when they buy, but it does not establish how often a retailer meets its original delivery promises. A worker has a short lunch break. A creator's rave about a restaurant does not establish its pickup preparation time. A small company needs responsive support. A sponsored comparison does not show how long customers waited for a human reply.

These are different decisions. Each needs relevant facts, with an explanation of their limits. Paid content and genuine recommendations can both be useful. The problem is that persuasion and commercial incentives can take the place of evidence about the service the consumer will receive. The full proposal links the supporting research and documented cases.

AI can make this problem harder to see by compressing discovery into one confident answer. It can also make it better by checking operational evidence and explaining why a business fits the buyer's needs. The data and the recommendation incentives both matter.

Let businesses publish what they can substantiate

The business chooses which measures to publish. Its source provider or an identified calculation service attests to a result with a defined method, population, period, coverage and current status. Private customer and transaction records stay behind the source boundary. Providers and industries can define useful measures without forcing every business into the same KPI list.

A source provider's attestation is distinct from a third party's calculation. A signature establishes origin and integrity; source accuracy and completeness require additional evidence. Unpublished metrics stay unknown. Businesses cannot quietly remove unfavorable eligible records from a declared population. There is no universal business score.

Make performance count in recommendations

Systems of record make the evidence available with permission. Agents assess its relevance, cite what influenced the decision and explain what remains unknown. Existing commerce protocols support the transaction that follows. This adds useful evidence before purchase to the commerce stack.

The economic opportunity is for better service to become easier to discover. A business that improves dispatch, billing or support should have a way to earn consideration beyond increasing its advertising budget. Source providers can help their customers demonstrate those improvements across discovery platforms.

AI platforms must keep paid placement and affiliate incentives separate from their assessment of consumer fit. Commercial relationships should be disclosed. A business offering no commission must remain eligible. Verification fees must not buy a favorable verdict. The format needs affordable participation, multiple issuers and shared governance including businesses and consumers.

A protocol cannot enforce a platform's incentives. Voluntary publication can also be selective, and an agent can overlook a business before reading its evidence. These are responsibilities to test openly, or this risks becoming another paid badge.

Test consumer benefit with source providers and agents

Nominate a product and technical owner. Select a native measure your system can responsibly support. Test consented claims from two source systems with two independent agents. Hold the buyer request and evidence fixed while changing commercial incentives; those changes must not improve the assessment of the evidence.

Then measure whether choices work out better: realized cost, missed commitments, resolution time and regret. Track participation costs and exposure for smaller and newer businesses. More clicks or purchases do not establish consumer benefit.

Black 4 has a public, open-source experimental reference and a fictional demo. Provider issuance, live integrations, platform commitments and measured consumer outcomes remain to be built. **Will your team help make business performance a usable input to AI recommendations?**

Reference and proposal: Open Commerce Performance on GitHub